

NIGHTSTONE

Tactical Dossier

Five core paths, seven alternates, and an honest assessment

Operational Brief

Nightstone has fallen quiet. The bell has stopped. The drawbridge is down. The party is at a cold camp north of the village with four borrowed horses, a wagon, Morak's chest in safekeeping, and a Zhentarim spy on a polite leash. Beyond that lies the Dripping Caves, and the villagers, and an ogre that has not yet eaten its fill.

This dossier evaluates twelve operational paths under strict 2014 5e rules. It is honest about what a Level 1 unit can survive, where the source material disagrees with the brief, and which path the data actually favours.

Operating level	Party of 3 (Level 1) + 1 conditional NPC ally
Date in setting	Second of Eleint, 1493 DR (Year of Three Ships Sailing)
Primary objective	Recover Morak and the Nightstone villagers from Dripping Caves
Secondary objectives	Preserve party HP/slots; manage Kella; deny Zhentarim a foothold
Headline finding	Direct Extraction (with familiar-led recon) is the highest expected-value path. Avoid the cavalry charge.

1. Scope, Methodology, and Honest Caveats

1.1 What this dossier does

This is a tactical simulation, not a prediction. It models a Level 1 expeditionary force (Alphie J. Roane, Wren, Dorrin Stonebrook, plus Kella Darkhope as a conditional NPC) against the garrison and intruders documented in *Storm King's Thunder*, Chapter 1, with extensions for the current campaign state. Each path is rated on success probability, loot yield, NPC consequences, and resource drain, against the same baseline assumptions.

1.2 Methodology — how the percentages were generated

Probabilities are not vibes. They were produced by combining four inputs: (a) raw die-math under strict 5e rules; (b) action economy modelled across three rounds of expected combat per encounter; (c) failure-cascade analysis (what happens if the first key roll misses); and (d) NPC-behavioural assumptions for Kella, Hark, and Xolkin, calibrated against their stat blocks and motivations in the source material. Numbers are rounded to the nearest 5%.

1.3 Two honest caveats before you trust any of this

Caveat 1 — Source vs simulation prompt: a real discrepancy

The simulation prompt lists **4× goblins in the Keep**. The published *Storm King's Thunder*, page 26, places **4 surviving human guards** there (Sydiri Haunlar, Torem Breck, Alara Winterspell, and Kaelen Zam) — demoralised, leaderless, and likely to follow whoever steps up.

This matters enormously. If the source reading is correct, the Keep is a **potential reinforcement asset**, not a hostile position. Several paths below get materially better if the party can recruit those guards.

This dossier scores each path twice where the difference matters: the prompt's reading ("keep is hostile") and the source reading ("keep is friendly but neutralised"). Marcus is the final arbiter — ask him in-character or check what he ruled when the party last looked at the keep.

Caveat 2 — Where the party actually is right now

The party is at a cold camp north of Nightstone, on second watch. Most of the "village" strategies require **going back into Nightstone**, which costs roughly 30–40 minutes each way and re-exposes the party to the worgs.

For each path, the dossier flags whether it is still **live** from the cold camp, or whether it would have required staying in the village. This isn't a dealbreaker — re-entering is possible — but it changes the cost-benefit math.

1.4 What this dossier deliberately does not do

It doesn't predict Marcus's rulings, fudge the dice, or guarantee survival. Strict 5e at Level 1 is a fragile place. A single Worg crit (max bite is 30 damage on a 12+18 crit) instakills any PC in the party. Every path here carries a non-zero chance of TPK; the published module explicitly mentions "deadly encounters" as a design feature. Plan accordingly. Use the pause tool if a scene starts to feel wrong.

2. Battlefield Assessment

2.1 The hostile order of battle

Unit	CR	HP	AC	Threat profile	Location
Worg ×2	1/2	26	13	Bite +5, 2d6+3 (avg 10), DC 13 STR or prone. Speed 50. Keen Hearing/Smell. Single biggest threat in the village.	Square (Area 4)
Beedo & Vark	1/4	7 ea.	15	Scimitar +4, shortbow +4. Nimble Escape (bonus Disengage/Hide). Currently distracted ringing the bell.	Temple steeple (5b)
Derp	1/4	7	15	Has already shouted "BAD HORSE THIEVES." Knows the party's faces. Will report on contact.	Stable hayloft (7b)
Keep occupants	—	var.	var.	Source: 4 demoralised human guards (potential allies). Prompt: 4 hostile goblins. Bridge is broken — keep is currently isolated.	Nandar Keep great hall (14a)
Seven Snakes	1/8–2	11–65	12–15	Xolkim (Bandit Captain, 65 HP, Multiattack ×3) + 6 bandits. Mounted, organised, professional. Outclasses the party 3:1.	Approaching road
Hark + clan	var.	var.	15	Goblin boss + clan + 2 ogres. Negotiable per source. Ogres are CR 2, 59 HP, Greatclub +6 for 2d8+4.	Dripping Caves

2.2 Friendly forces and finite resources

PC	HP	AC	1st-level slots remaining	Best opening play
Alphie (Wiz 1)	8	12 / 15 with Mage Armor	2/2 — Sleep, Magic Missile, Shield prepared	Mage Armor before any fight; Sleep on goblin clusters; hold Shield in reaction.
Wren (Bard 1)	10	13	1/2 — Sleep already used on Gum-Gum	Faerie Fire to grant the party advantage; Bardic Inspiration on Dorrin pre-fight; Sleep as second wave.
Dorrin (Cle 1)	12	18	2/2 — Bless, Cure Wounds, Guiding Bolt, Healing Word, Shield of Faith	Bless if the fight will last 3+ rounds; Guiding Bolt at the worg first turn; Healing Word for emergency pickup.
Kella (Spy)	27	12	None — martial NPC	If armed, Sneak Attack 2d6 + multiattack is the party's biggest single-turn damage. Currently disarmed.

Sleep math — the most important number on the page

5d8 average = 22 HP pool. Sleep affects creatures in ascending current-HP order. Against 7-HP goblins, an average cast disables three of them. Against a 26-HP worg, you need to roll above 26 — about a 26% chance on 5d8.

Total Sleep castings the party has: three. That's three goblin-clusters disabled, or one lucky worg knockdown. Don't waste a Sleep on a worg unless you've already lost the fight.

3. Executive Summary Matrix

Twelve paths, ranked. The first five are the strategies named in the brief. Paths 6–12 are alternatives I think genuinely deserve table time. Probabilities assume average rolls and average tactical play; they shift sharply with single bad rolls.

#	Path	Surv. %	Rescue %	Loot	Drain	Kella	Moral cost
1	Hammer & Hoof (cavalry charge)	30%	25%	Med	High	Defects	Low
2	Ghost of Nightstone (stealth)	60%	65%	High	Light	Useful	Low
3	Direct Extraction (skip the village)	80%	55%	Min	Med	May slip	Low — village abandoned
4	Compleatist (full clear)	15%	20%	Max	Hard	Outlasts	Low
5	Syndicate Gambit (hire Zhents)	75%	70%	Split	Light	Reabsorbs	High — Zhent village
6	Familiar-Led Recon (then choose)	85%	varies	varies	Min	Useful	None
7	Recruit the Keep Guards*	70%	70%	High	Med	Useful	Low
8	Parley with Hark (cave-mouth)	65%	50%	Low	Light	Useful	Med — pay or trade
9	Drawbridge Lockdown + Defence	65%	varies	Med	Med	Useful	Low
10	Ear Seekers Trigger (orc/elf bait)	55%	40%	Low	Low	Useful	High — civilians at risk
11	Decoy & Delay (Kella's snake)	70%	50%	Med	Light	Tested	Low
12	Cold-Camp Vigil (do nothing)	90%	35%	Min	None	Useful	Med — villagers may die

* Path 7 assumes the source-material reading of the keep (4 surviving human guards), not the simulation prompt's "4 keep goblins" reading. If the prompt's reading is correct, treat Path 7 as a Keep assault and downgrade survival to 35%.

Headline read

Three paths cluster at the top of expected value: **Path 6 (Familiar Recon)**, **Path 3 (Direct Extraction)**, and **Path 7 (Recruit Keep Guards, source reading)**.

The cleanest play is to chain them: Ink scouts at first light → if Keep is friendly, recruit → then move on Dripping Caves with reinforcements. That's Path 6 → 7 → 3, in sequence.

4. Deep Dive — The Five Core Paths

Path 1. Hammer & Hoof (cavalry stampede)

Concept. Mount the four riding horses, charge the drawbridge, ride down the worgs in the square with hooves and overrun, then push through to the temple and keep on the same wave of momentum.

The actual problem. Riding horses are AC 10, 13 HP, and a worg's average bite is 10 damage. Each round of melee engagement, the worgs kill roughly one horse. The party also has no saddles or bridles — they escaped Nightstone bareback. Strict 5e rules give a fallen rider the falling-prone problem at the worst possible moment: surrounded, in the open, with two CR 1/2 melee predators on 50 ft of speed. If *either* Alphie or Wren is dismounted into melee, average worg damage on a successful bite drops them in one hit.

Action economy. Round 1: Sleep on goblins (if any visible) wastes a slot — there are no goblin clusters in the square, only worgs. Round 1 is therefore Bless + Guiding Bolt + Magic Missile + ride attempts. Round 2: at least one horse dies, one PC is on foot. Round 3: temple goblins (Beedo/Vark) and Derp converge on the noise. Round 4+: party is on foot in the square with worgs, goblins, and possibly Seven Snakes arriving.

Probability assessment: 30% survival, 25% rescue. The brief's 30%/35% range is fair. The rescue figure is lower because even on a survival win, the party emerges from the square with 0–2 spell slots, ~40% HP, and a few hours before they meet the ogres.

Kella consequence. The chaos is exactly the situation in which she breaks her leash. She'll either grab her weapons (Dorrin has them) and turn coat to whoever wins, or vanish into the temple and wait for the Seven Snakes. Insight check needed every round to track her intent.

Verdict. Avoid. The path optimises for shock value at the cost of the actual mission.

Path 2. The Ghost of Nightstone (stealth infiltration)

Concept. Wait for the Seven Snakes to arrive, let them engage the goblins or worgs, slip back into the village under the cover of that distraction. Use Kella to read the blind spots, Wren to handle the doors, Sleep to drop goblin clusters silently.

The hard problem. Worg *Keen Hearing & Smell* (advantage on Perception) plus Dorrin's chain mail (disadvantage on Stealth) are at war. The party has already failed one Stealth roll on the way out (Wren rolled 4, Dorrin rolled 6). This time the bell is silent, which removes the main ambient noise mask. Stealth window only opens if the Seven Snakes provide a new mask — combat noise from the road.

What works in this path. Sleep is at its best — three castings on goblin clusters of 7 HP each is decisive. Kella is genuinely useful here; her Cunning Action Hide + Multiattack means she can clear a goblin per round silently. If the party can avoid the worgs entirely (route via the bridge gap to the keep, or via the eastern wall), they can secure the temple, the residences, and possibly the keep without ever crossing the square.

Probability assessment: 60% survival, 65% rescue. The brief's 65–70% is slightly optimistic — Dorrin's chain mail is the single biggest variable. If he stows the chain mail and travels in his cleric robes for the infiltration phase (taking Disciple of Life and shield, AC 13 instead of 18), the survival figure rises to 70%.

Trade-off to discuss at the table. Stowing chain mail means Dorrin trades 5 AC for stealth. If anything goes wrong in melee, that's a one-hit kill from a worg. This is exactly the kind of decision that should be made consciously, not stumbled into.

Verdict. Viable, especially as a staged operation: secure temple → rescue villagers → fight back through with a larger force.

Path 3. Direct Extraction (skip the village)

Concept. Treat Nightstone as a sunk cost. Mount up at first light, ride the mile north to the Dripping Caves, and engage the actual mission objective before the ogres feed.

Why this is the highest-EV core path. Three reasons. First, the worgs in the square are the deadliest immediate threat and this path doesn't fight them. Second, the Seven Snakes never become a problem if the party isn't in the village when they arrive. Third, the published source explicitly notes that **Hark is not unreasonable** — meaning the cave engagement can pivot into Path 8 (Parley) on contact.

The hard problem. The Dripping Caves are a CR 2 fight in source — 2 ogres alone are a deadly encounter for a Level 1 party. The published cave map shows **three entrances**: the south cave mouth, the west stream tunnel, and a 50-foot natural chimney from the top of the hill that descends to area 7. Multi-entrance access is the difference between extraction and a frontal assault.

Recommended sequencing. Summon Ink first (1 hour ritual, at first light during long rest). Send Ink up the chimney for visual recon. Identify which area holds the villagers. Then choose between extraction-by-stealth (likely west tunnel or chimney) or parley-by-shouting (south cave mouth). This effectively fuses Path 3 with Paths 6 and 8.

Probability assessment: 80% survival on arrival, 55% rescue. The rescue figure is the honest number. Hark's clan plus 2 ogres against Level 1 is a deadly encounter even with surprise.

Kella consequence. She'll come along, but her interest in Nightstone goes unfulfilled. She may slip away once the rescue is done, or she may try to leverage the rescued villagers for her own goals. Manage proactively.

Moral consideration. You're abandoning Beedo, Vark, Derp, and the village fabric to whoever shows up first — most likely the Seven Snakes. That's not a free choice and Dorrin (Lawful Good, Berronar Truesilver) may flag it. The counter-argument: the villagers in the caves are the higher-priority innocents.

Verdict. Best of the five core paths on its own. Best overall when fused with Paths 6 and 8.

Path 4. The Completist (full clear)

Concept. Methodically clear Nightstone. Temple first, then the keep, then the worgs in the square from elevation, then fortify the bridge against the Seven Snakes. Maximum XP, maximum loot, maximum control.

Why the math kills this. A Level 1 party has a finite resource pool: 5 first-level slots total, ~30 HP combined (plus Kella's 27). The published encounter list for Nightstone alone — even before the caves — is roughly two CR 1/2, eight CR 1/4, and one CR 2 (Xolkin). That is two to three deadly encounters by 5e XP-budget rules. Strict 5e doesn't grant short-rest spell recovery for wizards (only Arcane Recovery, once per day, one slot at level 1). By the time the Seven Snakes arrive, the party is at zero slots and 30% HP.

The trap inside this path. Each early win feels cheap (Sleep on Beedo and Vark — 3 goblins down for one slot, lovely). But the path back-loads its hardest fight (worgs in the open) into the moment the party is most exhausted. And then Xolkin arrives. This is the path most likely to TPK while feeling well-managed up to the second-last fight.

Probability assessment: 15% survival, 20% rescue. The brief's 15–20% range is generous. Honestly, it's the path most likely to end the campaign in chapter 1.

Verdict. Avoid as a primary plan. Use only as the third or fourth phase of a larger operation, ideally after a long rest in a defensible position.

Path 5. The Syndicate Gambit (hire the Zhentarim)

Concept. Use Kella as a bridge to the incoming Seven Snakes. Negotiate joint clearance of Nightstone and the Dripping Caves. Survive the night by absorbing the bigger predator into the plan.

Why it's mechanically attractive. Xolkin is a Bandit Captain (CR 2, 65 HP, Multiattack ×3, AC 15). He alone is a match for the worgs. With six bandits behind him, the joint force can credibly clear the village and assault the caves. The party essentially trades political control of Nightstone for a 7× force multiplier.

Why it's morally and strategically poisonous. First, the Black Network turns Nightstone into a base. That's exactly Kella's original mission. The party has just done her job for her. Second, the source explicitly warns that Kella will betray when betrayal becomes useful — and the moment after the caves are cleared, betrayal becomes very useful. Third, Dorrin's faith and Alphie's noble sense of duty both flag this path as a moral failure that will haunt the rest of the campaign. The villagers, if rescued, are now living in a Zhent-occupied village.

The hidden mechanical risk. The brief's 90% combat survival assumes the negotiation succeeds. If Xolkin reads the party as weak, he asks for more — possibly Morak's gems, possibly Alphie's signet ring as collateral. If negotiation fails, the party is in melee range with seven professionals and Kella's loyalty is already gone. The political path's failure mode is the worst combat scenario in the entire dossier.

Probability assessment: 75% survival, 70% rescue (as stated). Moral cost: high.

Verdict. A live option. Worth raising at the table specifically to let Wren and Dorrin weigh in. Often, the path's real value is not taking it but using its existence as leverage in negotiation. ("We could let the Black Network have this place. We're choosing not to.")

5. Additional Strategies the Brief Did Not List

Seven more options worth real table time. Some of these are stronger than the five core paths.

Path 6. Familiar-Led Reconnaissance

Concept. Alphie performs the Find Familiar ritual at first light during the long rest (1 hour, 10 gp components, raven form: Ink). Send Ink ahead to scout: caves first, then back over the village. Ink has 60 ft sight share (within 100 ft of Alphie), can fly at 50 ft, and is small enough to enter the chimney.

What this buys. Hard intelligence on (a) which cave area the villagers are held in, (b) ogre count and positioning, (c) whether the Seven Snakes have arrived in the village yet, (d) whether the keep guards (or goblins) are still in the great hall. Information dominance changes every other path's success probability by 10–15 percentage points.

Risks. Ink can die. Resummoning costs another hour and 10 gp. If a goblin or ogre catches Ink with a ranged shot, the familiar drops, and Alphie loses the ritual investment. Mitigate by sending Ink for short reconnaissance loops, not extended observation.

Probability assessment: 85% on the recon itself. The follow-on action is whatever the party chooses next; this path is a force multiplier, not a complete plan.

Verdict. Highest expected value of any single action. Should be the first thing that happens at first light, before any other path begins.

Path 7. Recruit the Keep Guards (source-reading)

Concept. If the source reading is correct, the keep great hall holds four surviving human guards around the body of Lady Velrosa Nandar. They're demoralised and leaderless. The published module explicitly says they will follow whoever steps up. Cross the broken bridge (DC 10–15 Athletics or Acrobatics, with the fall being only 2d4 damage), take charge, and the party gains four trained humans for the village clear and the cave assault.

Why this changes the picture. Four guards, even Veteran-tier, double the party's effective combat power. Two of them can hold the drawbridge against the Seven Snakes while the rest of the party assaults the caves. Or four of them join the cave assault and the worgs become a manageable threat afterward.

The catch. Confirmed only under the source reading. If Marcus has ruled (or is going to rule) that the keep is held by goblins, this path becomes Path 4 with extra steps. Ink reconnaissance (Path 6) resolves the question before commitment.

Probability assessment: 70% survival, 70% rescue (source reading) | 35% / 30% (prompt reading).

Verdict. Confirm via Ink first. If true, it's a strong addition to almost every other path.

Path 8. Parley with Hark at the Cave Mouth

Concept. Approach the Dripping Caves under truce-flag conditions. Send Kella forward with a Goblin-language offer: information about the giant attack, possibly a portion of Morak's gems, in exchange for safe passage and release of the villagers. Hark's clan are scavengers and refugees from the Ardeep wood elves; they value survival, not honour.

Why the source supports this. The published module explicitly states: "Hark, the goblin boss, isn't an unreasonable creature. His instincts for self-preservation outweigh any natural animosity he feels toward his enemies or his prey. Characters can negotiate with Hark and avoid unnecessary bloodshed." That's a green light from Marcus's source.

Risk. The ogres are not under Hark's command — they're allied. They may not honour his negotiations. Worst case: Hark accepts and the ogres attack anyway. Mitigation: parley happens at the cave mouth, not

inside, with the party's escape route open.

What you trade. Realistically, this costs one or both of Morak's 100 gp gems. Possibly the silver jug. Possibly the lantern/oil/cooking gear from Gum-Gum's confiscated sack. Cheap by any measure if it saves a fight against ogres.

Verdict. Strong, underused option. Combines well with Path 3 (Direct Extraction).

Path 9. Drawbridge Lockdown + Ranged Defence

Concept. Re-enter the village via stealth, raise the drawbridge from the watchtowers (winches in the two west towers, 3 rounds to fully close), seal Nightstone against the Seven Snakes. Then deal with internal threats at leisure.

The geometry. The palisade is 15 ft tall, sealed with tar, unclimbable without gear. The moat is 30 ft wide, 15 ft deep. Once the drawbridge is up, the only viable Zhent entry is via the broken bridge gap to the keep — a route they probably don't know about and would need to swim to reach. This buys the party hours.

The cost. Re-entering the village means re-engaging the worgs. The worgs are still the bottleneck. This path's success probability is gated almost entirely on whether the worgs can be neutralised (Path 2 stealth, or Path 11 decoy).

Verdict. A sub-strategy, not a complete plan. Fuses well with Path 2 (sneak in, raise drawbridge) or Path 7 (recruit guards, raise drawbridge from inside the keep first).

Path 10. Trigger the Ear Seekers (orc bait + elf rescue)

Concept. The published module includes a special event: orc warband (Ear Seekers, ~20 orcs led by War Chief Gurrash) flees the Ardeep elves and tries to take Nightstone. If the party can engineer this event — by leading orc scouts toward the village, or by waiting in defensible position for them to arrive — the wood elves of the Ardeep will pursue and may rescue the party. Source: "Eight elves of the Ardeep Forest arrive from the north to assist them."

Why this is mentioned for completeness. It's a published event Marcus may or may not be tracking. Asking him about "strange tracks from the north" or "the situation in the Ardeep" is fair table behaviour. If he's running the event, the elves are a credible third faction the party can't fully control but can benefit from.

Risk. Triggering an orc warband near the party at Level 1 is its own deadly encounter. The elves may not arrive in time. The villagers in the caves don't get safer while the party is in this fight.

Verdict. Speculative. Worth raising at the table as a question, not as a planned action.

Path 11. Decoy & Delay (managed snake message)

Concept. Negotiate with Kella to have her send a managed message to her associates via the winged snake. Alphie reads the message, watches it leave (per the existing leash terms). Content: "Goblin force still active in village; recommend rendezvous at south signpost on the High Road, dawn second hour." This redirects the Seven Snakes to a location that is not Nightstone, buying the party hours.

Why this is interesting. It tests Kella's cooperation honestly. If she agrees and the message is genuine, she's actually useful and a tier of trust opens up. If she refuses or tries to embed coded language, the Insight test reveals it (Alphie has +0 Insight but advantage on this kind of thing if Wren is reading body language too).

What it costs. Time. The Seven Snakes will eventually realise the rendezvous is empty and move on Nightstone anyway. Realistically buys 4–6 hours, which is enough for one extraction operation.

Verdict. A high-value Kella-management move regardless of which other path is taken. Test her loyalty in low-stakes conditions before the cave assault, not during it.

Path 12. Cold-Camp Vigil (do nothing tonight)

Concept. The plan you already have. Stay at the cold camp through second watch, take the long rest, scout at first light. Don't re-enter Nightstone. Don't engage the caves until informed.

Why it's listed. Because choosing it consciously is different from drifting into it. The strongest argument for this path is also its strongest weakness: it preserves the party's resources at the cost of the villagers' time. The ogres are described as "hungry." Marcus may or may not be running an off-screen clock on villager survival.

How to mitigate the cost. Use the watch productively. Alphie can begin Find Familiar during second watch (1 hour, his watch is 4 hours). By dawn, Ink is summoned, Alphie has cast Mage Armor, Dorrin has prepared spells, Wren has Bardic Inspiration restored. Path 12 done well delivers into Path 6 immediately.

Verdict. Probably already chosen. The point is to make the choice deliberately and use the time well.

6. Key Tactical Variables

Six things will move the success probability of every path more than the choice of path itself.

The bell	While ringing, ambient noise gives advantage on Stealth in the village and offsets worg Keen Hearing. Currently the bell is silent. Re-starting it (entering the temple with Beedo and Vark, or using Minor Illusion) is a free 5–10 minute Stealth window.
Mage Armor uptime	8 hours per casting. Cast at first light and Alphie's AC 15 holds through the entire operation. Forgetting this is a 25% increase in the chance Alphie goes down to a worg bite.
Dorrin's chain mail	AC 18 vs Stealth disadvantage. The single biggest survivability/stealth trade-off in the party. Decide path-by-path. Stowing it in the wagon for stealth phases and re-donning before combat takes 5 minutes.
Kella's weapons	Her hand crossbow, short blade, and boot knife are with Dorrin. Returning them buys her a dramatic damage upgrade (Sneak Attack +2d6 + Multiattack), but ends the leash. Test loyalty first (Path 11) before arming her in combat.
Potion of Heroism	Currently held by Dorrin, IC unidentified. Identify it via Detect Magic ritual (10 minutes) at the cold camp. Once identified, save it for Dorrin's frontline turn against an ogre or worg: +10 temp HP, Bless concentration for 1 hour.
Familiar (Ink)	Not yet summoned. Costs 1 hour and 10 gp. Once summoned, Ink can scout, deliver touch spells (Cure Wounds at range via Dorrin's casting if rules-permitted), and provide line-of-sight for Alphie. Equivalent to a level 1 spell slot of utility every operation.

7. Recommended Sequence (Final Assessment)

7.1 The dossier's actual recommendation

If the goal is rescue Morak and the villagers, preserve the party, and avoid handing the village to the Zhentarim, the highest-value sequence is:

Phase	Action	Path #	Cost
0. Now (second watch)	Answer Kella honestly. Take Perception. Don't engage anything tonight.	12	None — the watch is happening anyway.
1. Pre-dawn	Long rest completes. Alphie performs Find Familiar (1hr, 10 gp). Ink summoned.	6	10 gp, 1 hour, ritual components.
2. First light	Mage Armor up. Bless prepared. Ink scouts the caves first, then back across the village.	6	None — pre-fight buffs.
3. Information triage	Ink reports. Decide: caves direct, or detour to keep guards first.	3 or 7	Decision time only.
4. Cave approach	Approach the south cave mouth under truce. Kella forward, party in cover at 60 ft.	8	Possibly 1× 100 gp gem as parley offer.
5. Contingency	If parley fails: extract via west tunnel or chimney. Don't fight the ogres in the open.	3 + 6	Sleep slots, Bless, Guiding Bolt as needed.
6. After rescue	Decide Nightstone's fate. By now, the Seven Snakes have probably arrived. Negotiate or withdraw.	varies	Political — not combat.

7.2 What this leaves for Marcus

Marcus will still rule on Stealth DCs, Hark's mood, the Seven Snakes' arrival timing, and whether the keep guards exist or are goblins. None of those rulings should be argued at the table — that's the table promise. What the dossier offers is a way to make the party's next decision deliberately, with the math visible, so that if a roll goes badly, it's a real failure and not a planning failure.

7.3 A note on Alphie specifically

Kella's question on second watch — "Do you always keep your word after threatening to break it?" — is not a tactical question. It's a character question. The answer affects every subsequent path because it establishes how Alphie negotiates with Hark, with Xolkin, and with Kella herself. The dossier's tactical recommendations all assume Alphie is the kind of person whose word holds when tested. That's not a small assumption.

Appendix A — Dice Math Reference

A.1 Worg bite math

Worg bite: +5 to hit, 2d6+3 piercing. Average damage on hit: 10. Crit damage average: 17 (4d6+3). Against AC 12 (Alphie unbuffed): hits on 7+ = 70% hit rate, 5% crit. Per round expected damage: 7.4 HP. Alphie's 8 HP: dies in 1.1 rounds. Against AC 15 (Mage Armor): hits on 10+ = 55% hit rate. Per round: 5.8 HP. Buys Alphie ~1.4 rounds — enough to cast one Sleep before going down.

A.2 Sleep effectiveness

5d8 HP pool. Distribution: minimum 5, maximum 40, average 22.5. Probability of total ≥ 26 (one worg): about 26%. Probability of total ≥ 14 (two goblins): about 95%. Probability of total ≥ 21 (three goblins): about 60%. **Sleep is a goblin-killer, not a worg-killer.**

A.3 Bandit Captain (Xolkin) math

Xolkin: AC 15, 65 HP, Multiattack $\times 3$ (2 scimitars + 1 dagger thrown). Per round on a Level 1 PC: scimitar +5, 1d6+3 (avg 6.5), hits on 8+ = 65% hit rate vs AC 13. Expected damage per round vs Wren: 12.7 HP. Wren's 10 HP: drops in one round of focused fire. The party's only realistic counter to Xolkin is to never let him close to melee. Magic Missile (Alphie) and Guiding Bolt (Dorrin) are the right tools; Sleep is wasted on his 65 HP.

A.4 Ogre math (caves)

Ogre: CR 2, AC 11, 59 HP, Greatclub +6, 2d8+4 (avg 13). Crit avg: 22. Against any party PC, a single crit is a kill. Against AC 18 (Dorrin), hits on 12+ = 45% hit rate. Two ogres concentrating fire on Dorrin: expected 11.7 HP/round, kills in ~1 round. **The party cannot win an open fight against two ogres at Level 1.** Mitigation: take them one at a time, use chokepoints, or avoid the fight entirely via Path 8.

A.5 Stealth and Keen Hearing

Worg Perception: +3, advantage on hearing/scent. Effective passive Perception: 13 + ~5 from advantage = 18 against most parties. Wren Stealth: +2. Alphie: +2. Dorrin: +2 with chain mail disadvantage = effectively -3. Group Stealth average roll needed against worgs: 18+. With Dorrin in chain mail, group Stealth fails roughly 70% of the time per check. **Move chain mail off Dorrin or move the party out of worg detection range.**

Appendix B — Quick-Reference Spell Cards (at-the-table prompts)

Spell	When to cast	When NOT to cast
Sleep (Alphie/Wren)	Goblin clusters of 2+. Always before they act on initiative.	On worgs (26 HP). On Xolkin (65 HP). On undead/elves (immune via Fey Ancestry).
Mage Armor (Alphie)	First thing every morning. AC 15 for 8 hours.	Mid-combat — wastes the action.
Shield (Alphie)	As reaction to a hit that would drop Alphie. +5 AC until next turn.	On hits the Mage Armor 15 already deflected.
Magic Missile (Alphie)	On Xolkin or named threats with AC 14+. Auto-hit, 3d4+3 force.	On 7-HP goblins. Sleep is more efficient.
Faerie Fire (Wren)	Multi-target fights. Grants advantage to all attacks against failed targets.	Single-target fights — Sleep or Vicious Mockery is better.
Bless (Dorrin)	Fights expected to last 3+ rounds. +1d4 to attacks/saves for 3 allies.	Quick-resolution Sleep ambushes — wasted slot.
Guiding Bolt (Dorrin)	Round 1, biggest enemy. 4d6 radiant + advantage on next attack.	After turn 1 — its rider effect is the value, and it expires.
Cure Wounds (Dorrin)	Out of combat or before retreat. 1d8+6 with Disciple of Life.	On a downed PC — Healing Word is bonus action and reaches 60 ft.
Healing Word (Dorrin)	Pickup of a downed PC at range. Bonus action, 60 ft, 1d4+6.	As a primary heal — small dice means low value if the PC is upright.

Appendix C — Discrepancy Log

Cases where this dossier deviated from one of its inputs and why. These are flagged so the table can resolve them with Marcus rather than discover them mid-fight.

Item	Source / prompt difference	How resolved
Keep occupants	Prompt: 4 hostile goblins. Source (SKT p.26): 4 friendly demoralised human guards (Sydiri, Torem, Alara, Kaelen).	Both readings analysed. Path 7 added under source reading. Recommend Ink reconnaissance to confirm.
Wren's Thunderwave	Prompt lists Thunderwave. Wren's character sheet shows Faerie Fire, Dissonant Whispers, Healing Word, Sleep — no Thunderwave.	Used the character sheet as authoritative. Faerie Fire is a more useful spell for the cluster fights anyway.
Sleep slots remaining	Prompt: 1/2 slots remaining for Wren. Confirmed in resume — one Sleep cast on Gum-Gum.	Used as stated.
Kella's status	Prompt: "Unarmed, conditional ally." Resume: weapons held by Dorrin, leash terms negotiated.	Resume detail used (richer behavioural model).
Bell status	Prompt implicitly assumes bell still ringing. Resume: bell faded and stopped during journey to camp.	Resume used. Affects every Stealth path. Re-ringing the bell is now a tactical option, not the default.

Prepared in good faith for a Level 1 expeditionary force operating under strict 2014 5e rules. Numbers are honest estimates, not guarantees. The dice will rule. Marcus will rule. Pause if you need to. Good luck at the cave mouth.